

"THE EMOTIONAL BOND BETWEEN TEACHERS AND STUDENTS IS MISSING. **INSTEAD OF BEING MENTORS, TEACHERS ARE NOW MORE LIKE INSTRUCTORS"**

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"HERE, WE ARE IN A CONTINUOUS COMPETITIVE WORLD. **IT'S NOT POSSIBLE TO PERFORM ALL THE TIME...** THOSE WHO DON'T GET GOOD PLACEMENTS START STAYING ALOOF"

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dean of students' affairs at IIT Delhi. "We must examine the ground realities and take steps to rectify them."

This happens mainly because of the lack of sensitisation of upper caste students and even some teachers. Some high-caste professors consider Dalit students "uneducable", wrote educationist Kurmana Simha Chalam in his 2007 book *Challenges of Higher Education*. In April 2021, during the Covid lockdown, a series of videos of Seema Singh, an associate professor of English at IIT Kharagpur, making casteist remarks about SC/ST students in online classes, went viral on social media.

Such incidents can contribute to an inferiority complex among reserved category students and may even provoke guilt at having secured admission with lower grades. A 2013 King's College, London, study titled 'Faces of Discrimination in Higher Education in India: Quota Policy, Social Justice and the Dalits' concluded that casteist expression can leave Dalit students feeling that they are undeserving of their admission to higher-education institutions. The parents of Aniket Ambhore, an IIT Bombay student who died by suicide in 2014, recall how their son wanted to retake the JEE because he was ridiculed for not joining the institution on regular merit and wanted to get through the general category.

While faculty members and management may not express any discriminatory behaviour, students from backward communities, who are acutely aware of the perceived inadequacy of their educational backgrounds, find little time and support to bridge the gap. This scenario creates a feeling of diffidence in them. The IITs start conducting tests from the first month of joining and many students from marginalised communities score low marks as they don't get enough time to prepare.

Following Aniket's death, IIT Bombay had conducted an analysis based on students' cumulative performance index (CPI), which measures their academic scores. The data showed that 70 per cent of the students with a CPI below five were from SC/ST backgrounds. The CPI for most general categories and OBC students ranged between 6 and 9. Such poor performances create other forms of disparities. For example, to stand for elections in IIT Delhi, a student must show good grades with an aptitude for extra-curricular activities. "The Dalit students with low CPIs are unlikely to enjoy their democratic privileges," says a professor in the institute.

WHAT THE IITs ARE DOING

In Parliament, Sarkar said that all courses at IITs have now been introduced in regional languages to reduce stress among the students who had studied in vernacular-medium backgrounds. As a part of this initiative, the All India Council for Technical Education has released the complete syllabus of 12 different technical courses in regional languages.

According to Sarkar, the institutions are also focusing on extracurricular activities, including sports and cultural programmes, and assign one faculty advisor per 10 students to help with their academics and monitor the progress. Students, wardens and caretakers are sensitised to alert the authorities to signs of depression in fellow students so that timely clinical consultation can be provided. He also pointed to the Union government's initiative MANODARPAN, launched during the Covid-19 outbreak, which covers a wide range of activities to provide psychological support to students, teachers and families for mental and emotional well-being.

Rattled by the increasing incidents of suicide, several IITs are taking preventive measures such as counselling and mentorship for students with low grades and backlogs in their courseloads, reducing the curriculum requirements and creating a positive environment on the campuses. IIT Bombay director Subhasis Chaudhuri has announced that the institute is working towards changes in its undergraduate curriculum to make it more relevant and motivating for students, and to reduce some of the stress.